

Julia Youssef

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Recent UChicago Geosciences graduate with experience in paleontology, fossil preparation, and quantitative ecology. Experienced in working with museum specimens and audiences, communicating evolutionary concepts through presentations and visual media

EDUCATION

The University of Chicago

Chicago, IL

Bachelor of Sciences: Geophysical Sciences, Minor: Astrophysics

Jun. 2025

Course Highlights: Intro. To Python Prog. w/ Appl. to Astro Statistics, Phylogenetics in the Fossil Record, Comparative Vert. Anatomy, Dinosaur Science, Intro. to Invert. Paleobiology, Physical Geology, Earth History, Biodiversity, Biogeochemical Cycles, Geobiology

RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

Slater Lab – Multivariate Ecology on Mammalian Herbivores

Chicago, IL

Research Assistant

Jun. 2024 – Current

- Reviewed literature on available dietary studies on mammalian herbivores, particularly artiodactyls, for use in a Bayesian prediction of multivariate ecology from dental phenotypic data – with the goal of eventual use on extinct taxa – and collaborated with peers on adapting Carnivoran-based classifications in Wisniewski (2023) for herbivorous clades
- Gaining experience 3D scanning of Field Museum specimens and processing in R

Deep Purpl

Chicago, IL

Team Member

Sept. 2025 – Current

- Engaged with high volumes of customers in a fast-paced environment, adapting communication style to different needs and maintaining a welcoming atmosphere
- Managed orders, multitasked under pressure, and maintained consistent service quality during peak hours

Sereno Fossil Lab

Chicago, IL

Volunteer, Summer Student Lab Technician

Sept. 2021 – Dec. 2024, Summer Tech Jun. – Aug. 2023

- Presented paleontological concepts and the role of scientific illustration to public audiences during lab open houses, adapting explanations for different age groups and backgrounds
- Prepared fossil specimens (mm-scale trilobites to large vertebrate material) and created visualizations, diagrams, and casts for display, outreach, and educational use
- Participated in small, week-long expedition to exposed Morrison, Cloverly formations at base of Bighorn Mountains, involving excavating *Camarasaurus* vertebrae and other fossils in a team-based setting

Liew House Dorm Resident Assistant

Chicago, IL

Senior RA as of Sept. 2024

Sept. 2023 – Jun. 2025

- Fostered a positive living environment for 90+ residents, resolving conflicts and facilitating conversations across diverse groups
- Organized biweekly events and actively engaged residents to build community
- Collaborated with a team of 15+ staff to support a residential community of 1,000+ students

SKILLS & INTERESTS

Technical

- Fossil preparation, specimen cleaning, light scanning
- Art & Illustration (soft pastel, pencil, ink, digital)
- Microsoft Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint), Google Suite, Adobe (Photoshop, Illustrator)
- Computational (Python, R, RevBayes, PAUP, TNT)

Interests

- Rockclimbing, Running, Competitive Ballroom and Latin Dance
- Gardening (PhoenixFarms)
- Acting

ACTIVITIES & RESEARCH

Pterosaur Phylogeny

Dec. 2022 – Dec. 2023

- Performed an informal literature review of pterosaur crest morphology and phylogeny and quantitatively analyzed public morphological datasets. Gained experience in comparative cladistics and in visualizing different evolutionary hypotheses
- Illustrated pterosaur specimens and phylogenetic trees

Severn Fellows Program

Severna Park, MD

Severn Fellow

May, 2020 – May, 2021

- Researched multiple theropod dinosaur species to understand phylogeny, ecology, appearance, and anatomy into a work combining scientific research with visual communication

UChicago Paleontology Club

Chicago, IL

Board Member, Co-President

Dec. 2022 – Jun. 2025

- Co-led a student organization focused on paleontology, workshops, and discussions to engage students in evolutionary science